BUILDOUR AI BUILDER GUIDE 01

FROM BLUEPRINT TO BUILD: PICK YOUR FIRST SYSTEM

YOUR **AI SYSTEMS BLUEPRINT** NAMES FIVE TO NINE SYSTEMS. THIS GUIDE GETS YOU TO THE ONE YOU BUILD FIRST, CUT TO A SIZE YOU CAN FINISH.

BLUEPRINT FINALISED -- **PICK YOUR FIRST SYSTEM** -- BUILD DOCUMENTS -- SETUP -- BUILD -- SHADOW RUN -- GO LIVE

PURPOSE

Take your finalised AI Systems Blueprint and leave with one decision made and written down: which system you build first, at what scope, paired with what, and with which external clocks already started. The output is a one-page First Build Card. Every later guide in this series reads from that card.

WHO THIS IS FOR

The business owner (or the person they name) who holds a finalised AI Systems Blueprint and a working Claude Code setup, and is about to build their own system. It assumes the two Sunday sessions: you have built a calculator and a KRA-KPI system with Claude Code, and you have read System Thinking, System Design.

WHAT YOU NEED OPEN

Your AI Systems Blueprint (all six sections). Your Systems Brief. A blank page or a fresh Claude chat. No accounts, no code, no terminal in this guide.

TIME

One sitting of 60 to 90 minutes. Do not spread it across a week; the decision gets worse, not better, with time.

PREPARED BY

BuildOur AI

SERIES

Builder Guide 01 of the BuildOur AI Builder Guide series. Next: Builder Guide 02, writing the two build documents for the system chosen here.

ONE BLUEPRINT IN, ONE FIRST BUILD OUT. CHOOSE THE SMALLEST THING THAT REMOVES A DAILY PAIN, THEN START THE CLOCKS.

00 READ ME FIRST

WHAT THIS GUIDE DOES AND DOES NOT DO

Your blueprint was written to be complete: it names every system the business needs, in phases, with the pains each one removes and the rules each one must obey. That completeness is its job. It is also the reason you cannot build from it directly. A blueprint answers "what should exist"; a build needs "what do I make this week, and what do I leave out."

This guide closes that gap in four moves. First, you read your blueprint the builder's way, pulling out only what a build needs. Second, you score the Phase 1 systems on a worksheet and let the score pick. Third, you cut the winner down to one flow with one trigger and one outcome. Fourth, you decide whether a neighbouring system rides along, and you start the clocks on anything outside your control that takes calendar time.

> **THE ONE RULE THAT GOVERNS THIS GUIDE:** the first build is not the most important system. It is the system most likely to be finished, used daily by your team within a month, and to leave behind data that every later system reads. Importance comes second. A finished small system beats an unfinished big one every time, and your blueprint's Phase 1 was sequenced on exactly this logic.

What this guide does not do: it does not write the build documents (Builder Guide 02), it does not open accounts or touch code (Builder Guide 03 onward), and it does not change your blueprint. If the worksheet disagrees with your blueprint's Phase 1, the worksheet is telling you something about your data or your blockers, not about the blueprint. Note the disagreement on the card and carry on.

01 READ YOUR BLUEPRINT THE BUILDER'S WAY

SIX SECTIONS, SIX EXTRACTIONS

Your blueprint has a fixed shape. Each section carries one thing a builder needs, and nothing else from it matters at this stage. Go through it once with a pen, in this order, and write down only what each row asks for.

BLUEPRINT SECTION	WHAT TO EXTRACT	WRITE IT AS
Executive Summary	Your own success sentence: the line the blueprint quotes back to you ("six months from now…").	One sentence, verbatim. This is the test every build is measured against.
§1 Current State	The pains marked **daily**, and any pain with a rupee figure or a frequency next to it. Also the **money path**: the stations from enquiry to cash, with the manual ones marked.	A short list: pain, how often, what it costs. Then the money path as a line of 5 to 7 stations.
§2 Recommended Systems	For each system: its number, its name, the §1 pain it solves, and which other systems it **feeds** or **depends on** (look for "reads from", "once … is live", "built on").	A table of systems with two extra columns: feeds, depends on.
§3 Roadmap	Which systems sit in **Phase 1**, the **done when** line for Phase 1, your hours per week, and your deadline anchor.	Copy the Phase 1 line and the done-when line exactly. Write your hours and deadline beside them.

§4 Guardrails	Every “always human sign-off” item, every “AI may act alone” item, and the error protocol.	Two lists and one sentence. These are not optional in any build, however small.
§5 The Numbers	Orders per month, leads per month, quotes per month, repeat customer share, and any figure the blueprint flagged as needing confirmation.	The four numbers, plus a note of which ones are still unconfirmed.
§6 Next Steps	Anything the blueprint asked **you** to supply: data, samples, decisions, access.	A checklist with a tick box each. Unticked items are blockers, and they appear again in §05 of this guide.

READER’S NOTE: the §1 money path is the most useful thing in your blueprint for this guide. Every system in §2 sits on one station of that path. Your first build will sit on one station too, and the best first builds sit on the station where the most manual steps cluster: usually order intake, order tracking, or follow-up.

A WORKED EXAMPLE, USED THROUGHOUT THIS GUIDE

A 20-person made-to-order workshop. Its blueprint names seven systems in three phases. Phase 1 holds two: an order tracker with stage notifications (SYS-01), and a lead follow-up engine (SYS-02). The money path reads: enquiry, quote, order confirmed, production in five stages, dispatch, invoice, payment. The daily pains: the owner forwards every hand-off on WhatsApp, and nobody knows which orders are open. The extractions for this workshop are shown in each section below as the example fills in.

02 THE SELECTION WORKSHEET

LET THE SCORE CHOOSE

List every system your blueprint put in **Phase 1**. If Phase 1 holds a foundation (a shared data core, a “Track 0”), list it too, because it may be the first build on its own. Score each system on the six criteria below, 0 to 2 each, honestly. The scoring is not about how much you want the system; it is about how likely you are to finish it and have it used.

#	CRITERION	2 POINTS	1 POINT	0 POINTS
C1	**Pain is daily and named**	The §1 pain is marked daily and carries a rupee figure or a count	Daily, but unpriced	Weekly or rarer, or nobody measured it
C2	**The data exists today**	Everything the system reads already exists in a sheet, an app, or a register that can be exported	Most exists; some must be typed in first	The system reads data nobody has yet (drawings at 0%, a customer master that is “in my head”)
C3	**No external clock blocks day one**	Needs only your own accounts and your own data	Needs one external thing that takes days (an export, an admin login)	Needs something that takes weeks (a new business number on WhatsApp, a vendor’s permission, a verification)

C4	**The team's new habit is small**	The team keeps working where it already works; the system does the new thing	One new tap or one new screen per day per person	A new app, a new routine, or data entry nobody does today
C5	**Nothing customer-facing sends on its own**	The system works inside the business, or only drafts for a person to send	It sends routine updates on your AI-may-act-alone list	It would send prices, dates or commitments to customers
C6	**It leaves data the next systems need**	Its records are the foundation the rest of Phase 1 and Phase 2 read from	Useful to one later system	Standalone; nothing else reads it

Add the six scores. Then apply three tiebreakers in order:

01 **C2 wins ties.** Between two systems with the same total, the one whose data already exists wins. Data that does not exist is the single most common reason a first build stalls.

02 **Foundation beats feature.** If a foundation or a "Track 0" scores within 2 points of the top feature, build the foundation first and bring the feature along as its first screen (see §04 on pairing).

03 **The owner's hours decide scope, not choice.** Fewer hours per week does not change which system wins; it changes how much of it you build first (§03).

WHAT TO DO WITH THE RESULT: write the winner's number and name at the top of the First Build Card (§07). If the winner is not what your blueprint's Phase 1 said, write both and the reason. The usual reasons are a 0 on C2 or a 0 on C3: the blueprint assumed data or access that is not there yet. That is a clock to start (§05), not a reason to argue with the blueprint.

THE EXAMPLE, SCORED

The order tracker: C1 = 2 (daily, the owner forwards every hand-off), C2 = 2 (the stages and the open orders are on a board and in WhatsApp groups), C3 = 2 (internal only; team notifications can go through a plain channel first), C4 = 1 (each department head taps once per stage), C5 = 2 (nothing goes to a customer), C6 = 2 (every later system reads the order record). Total 11. The follow-up engine: C1 = 1, C2 = 1 (leads are in a diary), C3 = 0 (customer messaging needs the business messaging number), C4 = 1, C5 = 1, C6 = 1. Total 5. The order tracker goes first, by a wide margin, which is also what the blueprint said.

03 THE SCOPE-CUTTING RULE

ONE FLOW, ONE TRIGGER, ONE OUTCOME

A blueprint system card describes the finished thing. Your first build is the smallest slice of that card that removes the named pain. The rule for finding the slice:

THE SLICE RULE: one flow, one trigger, one outcome, one user group. If you cannot say "when X happens, the system does Y, and Z sees it" in one sentence, the scope is still too wide.

Take the winning system's card and make these five cuts, in order, until the sentence fits. Each cut is a deferral, not a deletion: what you cut goes into a "later" list on the card and returns in the next build.

CUT	ASK	KEEP	DEFER
1 · Channels	Which channels does the card mention? (WhatsApp, email, a marketplace, a phone call, a form)	The one channel where most of the volume arrives today	Every other channel. They plug in once the flow works.
2 · Roles	Who does the card say uses it?	The one or two people who feel the pain daily	Portals, dashboards and logins for anyone else
3 · Documents	Which documents does it generate or read? (quote, order sheet, delivery order, report, PDF)	One document, the one that is hand-made most often today	Every other format, every printout, every export
4 · Automation	Does the card let AI act alone, draft for approval, or only record?	One level below what the card allows: if it may send, build it to draft; if it may draft, build it to record	Auto-send and AI drafting. They switch on after a shadow run, never in week one.
5 · Integrations	Does it read from or write to your existing software?	A one-time import from an export (a CSV) so the build has real data	Live two-way links. Reading stays manual-export first; writing to your book of record is never in the first build.

> THE EXAMPLE, SLICED
>
> "When a job is confirmed, it becomes one order record with a stage; when a department head taps the stage done, the next head gets a message; the owner sees every open order and its stage on one screen." One trigger (job confirmed), one flow (stage to stage), one outcome (a message and a screen), one user group (the department heads and the owner). Channels deferred: customer updates. Roles deferred: the customer view. Documents deferred: the job sheet PDF. Automation: messages go to the team, not the customer. Integration: the existing board is exported once; it is not linked live.

What is never cut, however small the build

- **The guardrails from §4 of your blueprint.** A build that ignores a sign-off rule is not a smaller build; it is a wrong one. If a guardrail names a thing your slice does not touch, note "not in scope" on the card, but never drop the rule.
- **The "needs review" path.** Anything the system is unsure about is marked and shown to a person. This is a few lines of logic and it exists from the first version.
- **The record of what happened.** Every action the system takes is written down somewhere it cannot be edited. This is what makes the Day 7 review possible, and it is cheap to add on day one and expensive to add later.
- **A human switch.** A way to turn any automatic behaviour off in one place, without code.

> **THE HOURS TEST:** after the cuts, estimate the build in evenings, not days. At 2 hours a week, the first slice must be finishable in 4 to 6 sittings. At 5 hours, 3 to 4 sittings. At 8 or more, 2 to 3 sittings. If the estimate is higher, cut again; channels and documents usually have more to give. If the estimate is lower, do not widen: finish early, run it, then widen.

04 WHEN TO PAIR ADJACENT SYSTEMS

AND WHEN NEVER TO

Some blueprints put two systems in Phase 1. Sometimes they belong in one build; more often they do not. Pair them only when all three of these are true:

PAIRING TEST	PASS IF
Same data foundation	Both systems read and write the same core record (the same order, the same customer, the same lead). One migration serves both.
Same daily user	The same one or two people would use both. Pairing does not add a new person to train.
Same trigger or an adjacent one	The second system starts where the first one ends (an order record is created, so the payment radar reads it), and neither adds a new external clock.

If all three pass, the pair is one build with two screens, and the second system is usually a small addition. If any one fails, build them in sequence: the first finishes, runs for a week, and then the second starts on the data the first created.

Pairs that recur across blueprints, and the usual verdict

- **Order backbone + payment or outstanding radar.** Usually pairs: same order record, the radar is a view plus a reminder. Pair it, but build the radar to show, not to message, in the first version.
- **Lead capture + follow-up engine.** Usually pairs: same lead record, same salesperson. But the follow-up half is often blocked by the customer messaging clock (§05). Pair the record; defer the sending.
- **Quotation engine + order backbone.** Usually does not pair in the first build. Pricing logic is its own deterministic module with its own tests; the order record does not need it to exist. Build one, then the other.
- **Task board + KRA/KPI scorecard.** Never pairs in the first build. The scorecard needs months of task data to be honest; build the task board, let it run, then score.
- **Any system + a customer, dealer or vendor portal.** Never pairs. Portals are the last thing built on any platform, after the internal flow has held for weeks.
- **Foundation (data core) + its first feature.** Always pairs. A foundation with no screen is never used; the feature is how the team meets the foundation.

> **ON THE BLUEPRINT'S OWN PAIRS:** if your blueprint already wrote "Systems 1 and 2 together" in Phase 1, apply the three tests anyway. Blueprints pair by pain; this guide pairs by buildability. Where they disagree, build the foundation half first and write the other half as the next build on the card. You lose nothing; the second half starts with real data.

05 START THE CLOCKS NOW

WHAT TAKES CALENDAR TIME AND IS NOT IN YOUR HANDS

Some things your first or second build needs take days or weeks regardless of how fast you build, because they wait on someone else. Start every one that applies **on the day you choose your first system**, even if your first slice does not use it. By the time you need it, it is ready; start late and the build waits.

CLOCK	WHY IT TAKES TIME	WHAT TO DO TODAY	TYPICAL WAIT
A business messaging number for sending to customers	The platform verifies the business, and message templates are approved one by one. Moving a number off a personal phone has its own steps.	Decide which number the business will use. Begin business verification. List the five messages the system will send and write them as templates.	1 to 3 weeks
Export from your existing software (billing, accounting or ERP)	Admin access, an export format, and often the vendor's help. Some tools export nightly, some only by hand.	Find out who has admin access and whether customers, items, open orders and outstanding invoices can be exported to a spreadsheet. Take one export now, even if rough.	Days
Data that does not exist yet (the customer master in someone's head, drawings at 0%, paper registers)	Someone has to type it, and it is never the owner.	Name the person, not the role. Agree the first 20% that the first slice needs (the top repeat customers, the open orders, this month's leads). Give them a sheet with the columns.	1 to 2 weeks for the first 20%
Samples of real documents	Your screens should mirror the paper the team already knows.	Collect one filled example of each document the first slice touches: an order sheet, a quote, a delivery note, a register page. Photograph them.	One afternoon
Your own accounts (code hosting, database, hosting, the AI API key)	Quick, but a key with no billing set, or a project in the wrong region, costs a session later.	Confirm each account is on the business email, has two-factor on, and the AI key has billing set. These are your accounts, paid by you; the system you build calls your key.	One hour
A decision the blueprint left open (a reorder threshold, a credit rule, which entity an order belongs to, whether an old tool stays)	Only you can decide, and the code will encode the decision exactly.	Read §6 of your blueprint and your card's guardrails; write the answer to every open item in one line each.	One sitting

THE CLOCK RULE: a first build never waits on a clock. If your winning system needs a clock that has not run, build the slice that does not need it (the record and the screen), and let the sending or the live link arrive when the clock does. This is the other reason the slice rule in §03 defers sending and live integrations: it keeps the build moving while the world catches up.

06 IF YOUR BLUEPRINT SAYS OTHERWISE

THE BRANCHES

The default path in this series is one web application on one database, hosted online, with AI called where the blueprint needs it. Some blueprints deliberately say something else. The selection and scoping rules in this guide apply unchanged; only the shape of the build differs, and the branch is named here so you know which guide pages to read differently later.

BRANCH A · "SPREADSHEETS AND MESSAGING ONLY, NO NEW APP FOR THE TEAM"

The first slice is a clean sheet with fixed columns plus a small script or scheduled job that reads it and sends the team their messages. The "screen" in your slice sentence is a sheet view. Everything in §03 still applies: one sheet, one trigger, one outcome. The record of what happened is a second tab nobody edits. Score C4 as 2 for this branch, because the team's habit does not change.

BRANCH B · YOU ALREADY BUILT SOMETHING YOURSELF

A no-code app, a local program, a prototype. Your first build is not a new system; it is that thing, made real: on a proper database, with working logins, reachable by the team. Apply the five cuts to your own app: keep the one flow the office uses most, defer the rest. Your blueprint almost certainly already says this is Phase 1; the worksheet will agree, because C2 scores 2 (the data and the flow exist).

BRANCH C · AN EXISTING SYSTEM STAYS THE BOOK OF RECORD

Billing, accounting, an ERP. This is true for most blueprints and is not really a branch, but it sets one rule for the first build: you read from it by export, you never write to it, and confirming anything official stays a human action inside that system. The first slice does not link to it live. Score C3 and C5 with this in mind.

BRANCH D · PHASE 1 IS A FOUNDATION OR A DATA TRACK, NOT A FEATURE

Build the foundation with one screen on it (§04, last pair). The screen is whichever Phase 1 feature scored highest on the worksheet, cut to its smallest view.

07 THE FIRST BUILD CARD

THE ONE PAGE YOU LEAVE WITH

Fill this in by hand or in a document. It is the input to Builder Guide 02 and every guide after. Keep it to one page; if it spills over, the scope is too wide.

FIELD	YOUR ENTRY
Success sentence (from the Executive Summary, verbatim)	
Money path station the first build sits on	
First system (number and name from §2 of the blueprint)	
Worksheet score, and the runner-up with its score	
If different from the blueprint's Phase 1: what and why	
The slice sentence ("When X happens, the system does Y, and Z sees it")	
Kept: channel · roles · document · automation level · integration	
Deferred to the next build: the list from the five cuts	
Paired system, if any, and which of the three tests it passed	
Guardrails that apply to this slice (from §4, verbatim)	
Guardrails not touched by this slice (named, so they are not forgotten)	
Clocks started today, with the owner of each and the date started	
Open decisions answered (one line each)	
Data the first slice needs, and who is typing it by when	
Estimated sittings at your hours per week	
Done when (one observable state, copied from or sharper than the blueprint's Phase 1 done-when)	

Drafting the card with Claude

Open a fresh chat, attach your blueprint, and paste the prompt below. Then correct every line yourself; the draft is a starting point, and the scores in particular must be yours, because Claude cannot see which data exists in your office.

> *"You are helping me choose the first system to build from my AI Systems Blueprint, attached. Read it fully. Then: (1) list every system in Phase 1 with the §1 pain it solves, what it feeds, and what it depends on; (2) score each on six criteria, 0 to 2 each: pain is daily and priced; the data it reads exists today; no external dependency takes weeks; the team's new habit is small; nothing customer-facing sends on its own; it leaves data later systems need. Show your reasoning per score and mark any score you are unsure of, so I can correct it; (3) for the top scorer, write a one-sentence slice in the form 'When X happens, the system does Y, and Z sees it', then list what you cut across channels, roles, documents, automation level and integrations; (4) copy the guardrails from §4 that apply to this slice, verbatim; (5) list every external dependency this system or its Phase 1 neighbour needs that takes calendar time; (6) fill the First Build Card fields in order. Do not invent any figure or fact not in the blueprint. Where the blueprint flagged a number as unconfirmed, say so."*

08 THE GATE

YOU ARE READY FOR BUILDER GUIDE 02 WHEN

- The First Build Card fits on one page and every field has an entry, including "none" where that is true.
- The slice sentence has one trigger, one flow, one outcome and one user group, and a person outside the business could read it and say what the system does.
- Every guardrail from §4 of the blueprint is on the card, either as "applies" or as "not touched", and none is missing.
- Every clock in §05 that applies has a named owner and a start date, and the first data request has been handed to the person typing it.
- The sittings estimate fits your stated hours per week within 4 to 6 sittings.
- You can say, in one line, what the next build after this one will be. If you cannot, the deferred list is too short or too vague.

One failure holds the gate. Fix it in this sitting; do not carry it into the build documents, because every later guide assumes the card is true.

WRITTEN FOR BUILDERS HOLDING A FINALISED AI SYSTEMS BLUEPRINT. NOTHING IN THIS GUIDE CHANGES THE BLUEPRINT; IT CHOOSES FROM IT.
THE EXAMPLE WORKSHOP IS INVENTED. SCORES, SLICES AND CLOCKS ARE YOURS TO DECIDE; THE WORKSHEET ORDERS THE DECISION, IT DOES NOT MAKE IT.